



The Global Burden of Mental Illness: Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions, their disease burden, and the persistent gap between need and treatment.

Global data (World, 2023). Source: Our World in Data (2023), IHME Global Burden of Disease (2025).

Hundreds of Millions Affected: 1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major Depression

1 in

3

women

will experience major depression in their lifetime

1 in

5

men

will experience major depression in their lifetime



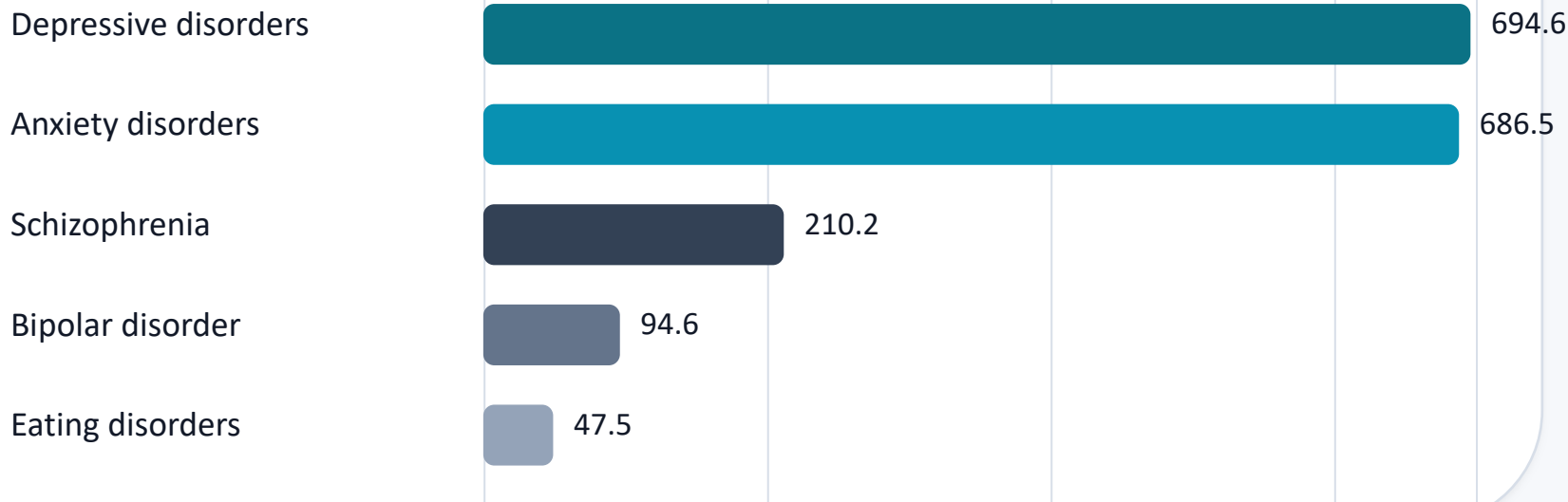
Why this matters for policy

- Mental health conditions affect well-being, work, and relationships.
- Conditions range from common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar disorder).
- High lifetime risk implies large, sustained demand for services and prevention.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate: ~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K Respectively

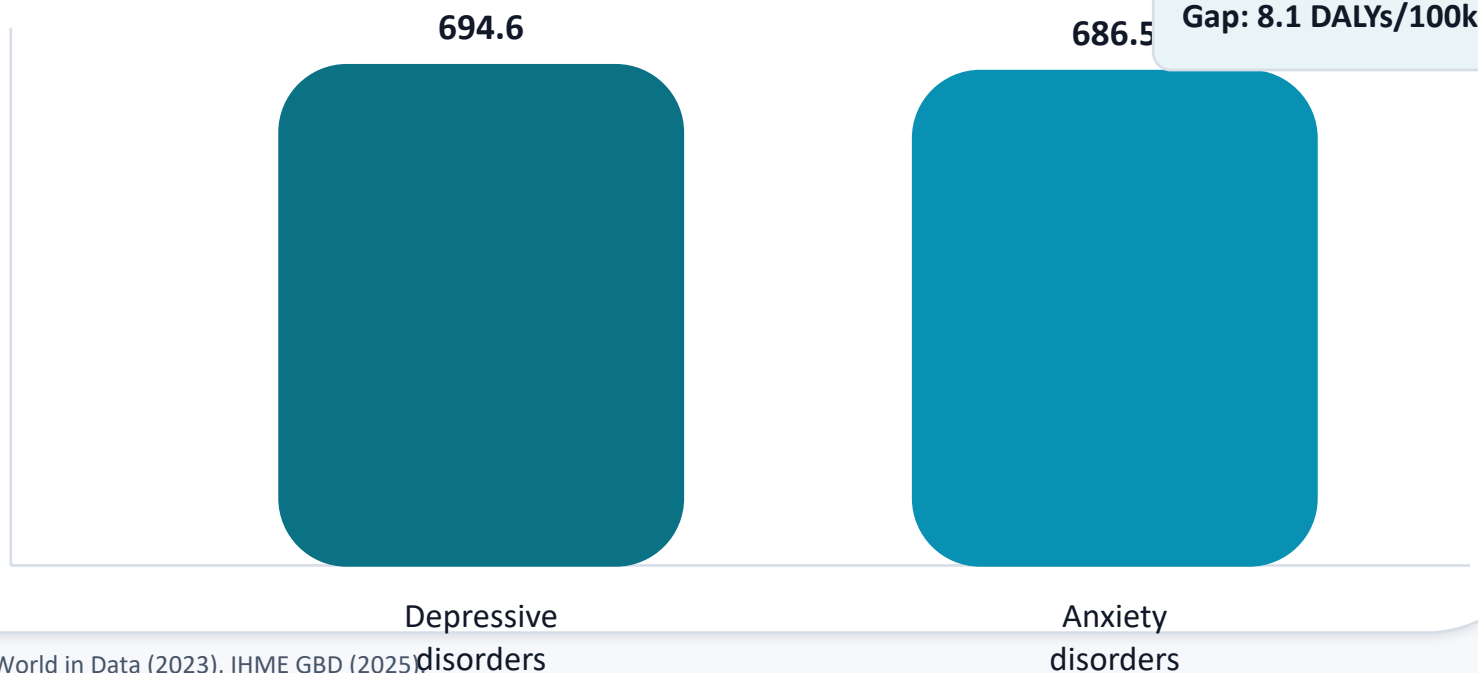


DALYs per 100,000 people (World, 2023)



Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide

Nearly identical DALY rates: depressive vs anxiety disorders (World, 2023).



Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact



Population-level burden vs. severe individual disability

Depressive disorders



Anxiety disorders



Schizophrenia



Bipolar disorder



- Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder are less common but have a large impact on individuals' lives.
- Policy needs both scale (common disorders) and continuity of specialized care (severe conditions).

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality



Effective care exists—coverage and quality often do not



Stigma

People may be uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to professionals or even people they know.



Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality.



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes true prevalence hard to estimate; burden may be higher than reported.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations

Global surveys show wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression:



Taking prescribed medication



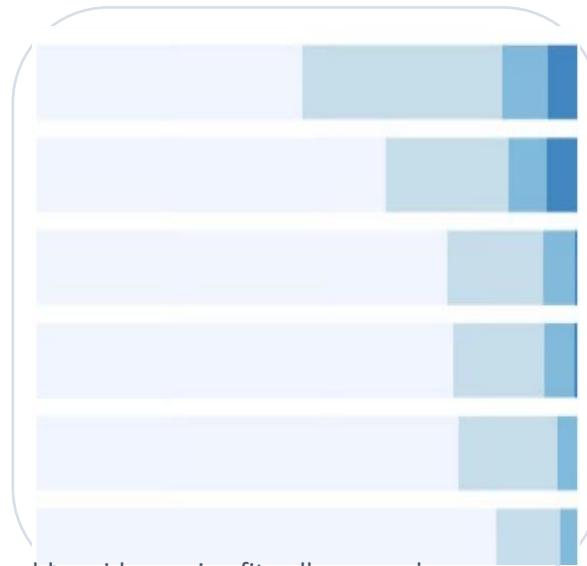
Engaging in religious or spiritual activities



Talking to friends or family

Responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and health-system factors—policy should avoid one-size-fits-all approaches.

Reference: Our World in Data



Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- Depressive and anxiety disorders dominate mental health DALYs globally (World, 2023).
- Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder have lower population burden but severe individual impact.
- Treatments exist, yet access and quality are often inadequate.
- Stigma and discomfort disclosing symptoms suppress help-seeking and make prevalence harder to estimate.
- Prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.